

the terrorists are invariably their followers," says Abdullah Patel, a Bareilvi preacher from Bharuch. In Pakistan, another frontline state, where Deobandis have declared war on the moderates, the war is predictably a little more vicious. A decapitation explosion at a religious congregation in Karachi on April 11, 2006, killed the entire senior leadership of the Sunni Tehrik, an anti-Deobandi-Salafi Sunni organisation of Pakistan. Fifty other innocent civilians, many of them lower-level leaders of the Tehrik, were killed in the explosion. In India too, Barelvis have been at the receiving end of terror attacks. A blast at the Ajmer dargah in October last year, frequented by Barelvis, killed three worshippers.

A vast majority of terrorists invariably follow the Deoband-Tablighi or the Ahle Hadis tenets. "Terror outfits seem to draw their raw material from these groups," says G.L. Singhal, former ACP of Ahmedabad Crime Branch. These groups do not necessarily tell their cadre to don suicide jackets and blow themselves up for the cause of Islam. But the security threat from them stems from challenges in dealing with people who dream of recreating a universal Muslim community cut from all existing societies, including Muslim society.

"These second-generation Muslims—some of them, of course, not all of them—feel alienated from a pristine culture of their grandfathers. They don't care about how one lives in a Moroccan village, they feel so alienated by the modern Western culture. And by not reverting, but by joining a neo-fundamentalist movement, which tells them, 'Don't care about society, any kind of society; don't care about culture; don't care about politics; just try to be a good Muslim and to recreate the true Muslim community,' they feel at home. They



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would say, this is an identity for me," argues Olivier Roy, author of *The Failure of Political Islam*. It is to this new identity that fundamentalists address the injustice against the community. In recent years, the demolition of the Babri Masjid, the Mumbai riots of 2003 and the Gujarat riots of 2002 have formed powerful propaganda tools.

On the face of it, there seems to be no contest. The non-Wahhabis still command nearly 80 per cent of the Muslim community and are seemingly in no danger. Yet, their moderate voice is well in danger of being swamped. From Bareilvi mosques in the north to ritual art forms in the south, Wahhabis and their offshoots are threatening

years of assimilation. When a more organised and vocal minority takes over, mostly with a petro-dollar funded message, choreography and persona, a hapless majority fights back weakly.

"The Wahhabis are conducting an aggressive campaign of mobilisation for a particular brand of Islam with the other sects in a permanent defensive posture. Their's is a violent interpretation of jihad and has the enormous potential to create and sustain mobilisation and recruiting base of extremist movements in India," says Ajai Sahni, executive director, Institute for Conflict Management.

"From just 28 websites eight years ago, there are over 1,000 websites dedicated to spreading